

The Fussy-Eater Rescue

10 calm things to say at the table tonight — that stop the fights, without bribes or tears.

Mealtimes don't get calmer by pushing harder — they get calmer when the pressure comes off. Each line below lowers the tension so your child can get curious in their own time. You don't need all ten. Pick one tonight and say it lightly.

Say this instead

1

You don't have to eat it. You can just say hello to it.

Why it works — Removes all pressure — and pressure is exactly what makes kids dig in. Curiosity grows the moment the demand disappears.

Instead of — *"Just one bite, please!"*

2

Where do you think this grew — on a tree, a vine, or under the ground?

Why it works — Curiosity before consumption. A child who is interested in a food is far more likely to try it.

Instead of — *"It's healthy, that's why you have to eat it."*

3

This one's really crunchy. I wonder if yours is too?

Why it works — Invites them to explore the texture with zero pressure to swallow. Noticing is the first tiny 'try'.

Instead of — *"Stop playing with your food and eat."*

4

You're our taste-tester today. Thumbs up, thumbs down, or thumbs sideways?

Why it works — Turns 'no' into a fun rating. They get control — the very thing they were fighting for.

Instead of — *"Why do you never eat anything I make?"*

5

Let's just keep it on the side of your plate, to keep us company.

Why it works — Gentle exposure. Kids often need to see a food many times before they'll taste it — and that's completely okay.

Instead of — *"Finish everything on your plate."*

6

Want to help me wash the beans / tear the spinach?

Why it works — Connection and ownership before the meal even starts. Kids love eating what they helped make.

Instead of — *"Dinner's ready — sit down now."*

7

I'm going to smell mine first. Want to smell yours?

Why it works — Smelling is a low-risk first step that builds comfort long before any tasting has to happen.

Instead of — *"Just try it, it's not even spicy."*

8

Some days our tummy says yes, some days it says no. Both are fine.

Why it works — Takes the all-or-nothing pressure off, so a single 'no' never has to become a battle.

Instead of — *"But you liked it yesterday!"*

9

Which colour should we add tonight — green, orange or red?

Why it works — A small choice plus 'eat the rainbow' creativity. Choosing makes them part of the decision.

Instead of — *"Eat your vegetables."*

10

You tried something new today. That was really brave.

Why it works — Praise the effort, not the eating. Brave-trying is the habit we want to grow — win or lose.

Instead of — *"See? That wasn't so hard."*

How to use this tonight

1. Pick just **one** phrase — you don't need all ten.
2. Say it lightly, then carry on. Don't wait, watch or hover.
3. Use the same gentle approach over a few days. Calm and consistent beats forceful, every time.

This is the heart of the Eat Your Green **4C method**: Curiosity · Connection · Creativity · Consistency.

Loved this? Get the full gentle system.

The **Eat Your Green Guide** turns these moments into a simple 7-day plan — calm meals, happy little tries, no bribes. Read it tonight on your phone.

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